



GUYANA

Capital city: Georgetown
Area: 83,000 sq miles (214,970 sq km)
Population: 765,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Christian 57%, Hindu 33%, Muslim 9%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Guyana dollar
Adult literacy rate: 97%
Life expectancy: 62 years
People per doctor: 5,000
Televisions: 55 per 1,000 people

SURINAME

Capital city: Paramaribo
Area: 63,039 sq miles (163,270 sq km)
Population: 436,000
Official language: Dutch
Major religions: Christian 48%, Hindu 27%, Muslim 20%, other 5%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Suriname dollar
Adult literacy rate: 94%
Life expectancy: 70 years
People per doctor: 3,333
Televisions: 153 per 1,000 people

FRENCH GUIANA*

Capital city: Cayenne
Area: 34,749 sq miles (90,000 sq km)
Population: 186,917
Official language: French
Major religions: Christian 75%, other 25%
Government: Ruled from France as part of multiparty democracy
Currency: Euro

*French Guiana is not an independent country. It is a French overseas department.

KOUROU

More than 15,000 people live and work at Kourou, the launch site for the European Space Agency. *Ariane* rockets put satellites and probes into space on behalf of European nations.

GUYANA

ONLY ABOUT 765,000 PEOPLE live in Guyana, most of them on the coastal plain in and around the capital city of Georgetown. Guyana takes its name from a native Indian word meaning "Land of Many Waters," for the country is crossed by numerous rivers draining north into the Atlantic Ocean. Guyana was once a British colony, but gained independence in 1966. Today the country exports sugar and bauxite and also possesses vast natural resources, including lumber and minerals.

THE POPULATION

Most people in Guyana are descendants of workers or slaves brought into the country to labor on the sugar plantations. African slaves were shipped over between the 17th and 19th centuries. After slavery was abolished in the British Empire in 1833, people from the Indian Subcontinent arrived to take their place. The Caribs, the original Indian inhabitants, now number no more than 50,000 people.



SUGAR PLANTATIONS

The Dutch were the first Europeans in Guyana, establishing a settlement on the Essequibo River in 1615. They planted sugar, cocoa, and other tropical crops, importing slaves from West Africa to help them run the plantations. The British took control of the country in 1814 and concentrated on growing sugar. Today sugar, rice, bauxite, and gold are the main exports.

SURINAME

FORMERLY KNOWN AS DUTCH GUIANA, Suriname was originally owned by the British, who exchanged it for the Dutch island of Nieuw Amsterdam, now called Manhattan, in 1667. Suriname became independent from the Netherlands in 1975. Because the country is so poor, about 200,000 Surinamese live in the Netherlands and send money back to support their families at home.

PARAMARIBO

The capital city of Suriname lies just inland from the Atlantic coastline. The Dutch origins of the city can be seen in the Dutch-style architecture and in street names such as Konigstraat. Most of the city is built of wood, including the 19th-century cathedral of St. Peter and St. Paul with its tall spires. Half the population of Suriname lives in Paramaribo.



FRENCH GUIANA



THE ONLY REMAINING colony in South America is French Guiana. For years the colony was famous for its offshore prison on Devil's Island, but today it is better known for its role in the European space program. The colony is dependent on France for much of its income, and it now has one of the highest standards of living in South America.



The ocelot is an endangered animal.

FORESTS

Most people live on the coast and the interior is largely untouched tropical rain forest. Thousands of different species of flora and fauna, including ocelots, jaguars, and pumas, plus a variety of reptiles, inhabit the forests.

Find out more

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